
Jacob Obrecht

c. 1457–1505, FRANCO-FLEMISH

During his own time, Obrecht was a celebrated figure, and among the Franco-Flemish musicians of his period he now ranks second only to Josquin des Prez. The son of a city trumpeter in Ghent, he was primarily a religious composer, holding positions in various churches and cathedrals in Antwerp, Bruges, and elsewhere. (Some of these posts were short-lived and he seems to have been rather restless in his movements.) However, he also wrote secular music and he ended his career working at the court of Duke Ercole d'Este in Ferrara, where he died of plague. Obrecht excelled chiefly as a composer of Masses—about 30 by him survive, showing a style that is fluid, graceful, and sonorous. His secular works include numerous songs in Dutch, ranging from the lighthearted to the serious.

KEY WORKS: *Missa Fortuna desperata* (Desperate Fate Mass), c. 1490; *Missa Sub tuum praesidium* (Mass Under Thy Protection), c. 1500; *Missa Maria zart* (Mass for Gentle Mary), c. 1500–1505

John Taverner